

Chapter 13

Instructor's Manual

This chapter covers:

- A discussion of immigration to America, the notion of the American melting pot, and multilingualism
- An overview of the number of immigrants and bi- and multilingual people in the United States
- A discussion of discrimination against certain L2 accents

Sample answers to the questions from the text and the website

From the textbook

None.

From the website

Audio

1. Listen to the samples of people speaking English with different L2 accents. Which of these accents do you think would be most tolerated or embraced in your area? Which would be least tolerated or embraced? Why?

Sample answer: I think the most accepted accents in my area would be those from Europe, especially French and Dutch. I think the least accepted would be those from Middle Eastern countries and any accents that might be mistaken for a Mexican accent. I think these different opinions about accent are based on race and the amount of respect that people have for the cultures where those languages are spoken. Since the U.S. has been at war in the Middle East for quite some time, people may have negative reactions to accents from that region. The controversy over illegal immigration in this area (California) is typically focused on immigrants from Mexico and Central and South America, so I think accents from those regions would not be embraced by many people here. In contrast, the European languages would be more accepted because the people there are white and the cultures that accompany those languages are highly respected.

I think the case of the Spanish accent provides a good example of the bias attached to perceptions of L2 accents. In this area, I think a Spanish accent on a person of European ancestry would be evaluated positively whereas a person of mixed or indigenous ancestry whose L2 accent came from a variety of Spanish spoken in the New World would not be evaluated in such a positive way. The different evaluations of an accent based on the same language (with dialectal differences) provide good evidence that the judgments of accents are based on the speaker more than the accent.

Videos

“Town Passes English Only Law”

Fox News, 7/28/10

http://video.foxnews.com/v/4295607/town-passes-english-only-law?r_src=ramp

“ACLU Targets Town’s English-Only Law”

Fox News, 4/30/2010

<http://video.foxnews.com/v/4204792/aclu-targets-towns-english-only-law>

1. How would you evaluate the arguments for the English-only policies described in these videos in light of the content in Chapter 13?

Sample answer: The English-only arguments in these videos illustrate the obsession with the “utopian” idea of a linguistically homogenous American society that speaks only English. In the first video, the city councilman says that the decision to make English the official language in their town was to save money, but since the town is currently not spending any money on translation programs now, their law is not saving them any money during this financial crisis. This leads me to believe that the motivations for the law are based on language ideology rather than legitimate financial motives. In the second video, the city councilman does not have a justification for the law, but argues that it does not violate any civil rights because people who don’t speak English could bring someone to translate for them. This argument puts the burden of translation entirely on the person in need of services and I think that people who are not very fluent in English could have restricted access to government services because they may have a hard time finding a friend or hiring an advocate who could help them get the services they need. In addition, the city councilman in the second video says there is not a significantly large immigrant population in his town, which leads me to believe that there could not have been many problems with a lack of an English-only policy and makes me wonder why the law came up in the city council in the first place.

Suggested activities and discussion questions

1. Ask your students to interview participants to ask them if they think English should be the official language of the United States (or your city or state) and have them share the responses they received with the class. What patterns emerge from the pooled data? What do the students think about these responses in terms of the language ideologies behind them?
2. Ask your students to interview participants to find out what L2 accents they prefer and disprefer and why they feel the way they do. Have them bring the responses into class to share. What patterns emerge from this data? What were the most common justifications people had for why they liked or disliked an accent? How would the students evaluate the responses in light of the content in this chapter?
3. Ask your students to interview someone who speaks English fluently with an L2 accent in order to find out what positive or negative experiences that person’s L2 accent has caused. Have the students share their findings with their classmates and discuss the ramifications of accent discrimination.

4. If you can find elderly people to talk to, see if their favorable or negative reactions to particular accents are similar to the younger generation. What accents might people who were alive during WWII find objectionable? Why? What (if anything) does this say about language ideology?

5. To enhance discussion of this chapter, please visit the companion website and check out the audio and video clips available for use in your classroom.